During his earlier tenure, (Congress) party work and government work, as far as possible, were kept separate. But during Kao's second phase at work, the actual decision-making process on Punjab and Sikh affairs had shifted from the PMO in South Block and the MHA in North Block to 1 Akbar Road.

As senior advisor, Kao was also responsible for Indira Gandhi's safety. Kao had set up a coordination committee for her security comprising senior representatives of security departments and intelligence agencies. It met daily under his chairmanship and discussed intelligence inputs related to her security and her daily programme. Rajiv Gandhi, who did not hold any position in the government at the time, took close interest in the actions taken to strengthen the PM's physical security. According to B. Raman,

> As per his desire, two of his closest personal advisors used to attend these meetings in order to give their suggestions and keep him informed of the discussions and the action taken. Since they too did not hold any position in the Government, they were not entitled to attend these top-secret meetings, in which classified information was discussed. Despite this, in order to satisfy him that everything that was required to be done for her physical security was being done, Kao let them attend even though they did not have the required security clearance, but the minutes of these meetings did not show their presence. [9]

Incidentally, Rajiv Gandhi and 'two of his close associates' also held a number of meetings with Akali Dal leaders in a New Delhi guesthouse of the R&AW. Raman 'was given the task of making arrangements for these meetings, recording the discussions, transcribing them and putting up the transcripts to Kao or briefing Indira Gandhi.' [10]

Regarding the removal and redeployment of Sikh security staff at Indira Gandhi's residence, B. Raman writes, 'The withdrawal of the Sikh officers from close-proximity duties came to the notice of Indira Gandhi. Some say she noticed it herself. Others say one of